

Redesigning Item Selection Experience on Zomato to Improve Trust and Decision-Making

Overview

Platforms like Zomato have optimized heavily for discovery and delivery efficiency. However, there is a gap in the **item selection experience**, where users make final ordering decisions.

This case study focuses on improving:

- **Information clarity at item level**
- **Interface-driven decision support**
- **User trust during ordering**

This project identifies and addresses a key user trust gap in Zomato, where the use of generic food images leads to a mismatch between user expectations and actual delivery outcomes.

A two-phase user research study with 30 participants was conducted to validate the problem and test a proposed solution. In the discovery phase, 93.3% of users reported experiencing inconsistencies between displayed images and delivered food, while 83.3% indicated reliance on images despite low trust. These findings highlighted a critical issue impacting user decision-making and platform credibility.

Based on these insights, an MVP was defined to improve visual authenticity and reduce decision friction. The solution focused on prioritizing restaurant-specific images, introducing a “Photos by Restaurant” section, and enhancing review filtering for better discoverability of real user-generated content.

In the validation phase, users interacted with the MVP prototype, which achieved an average rating of 8.6/10, with 80% of participants rating it 8 or higher.

Feedback indicated improved clarity, trust, and overall usability, while also identifying trade-offs such as increased information density.

These estimates are directional and grounded in user research, demonstrating how targeted UX improvements can impact both user experience and business outcomes

Problem Statement

The current interface creates **decision uncertainty** due to gaps in visual accuracy and structured information.

1. Inaccurate Item Representation

- Food images are often **generic or externally sourced**
- Do not reflect actual restaurant-prepared dishes

Impact:

- Expectation mismatch
- Lower trust in platform

| 93.3% of users reported mismatch between images and delivered food

2. Missing Item-Level Information

Critical fields are either missing or inconsistent:

- Calories (kcal)
- Allergens
- Serving size (number of people)

Impact:

- Users lack clarity while ordering
- Increased cognitive effort
- Poor decision confidence

3. Inefficient Review Visibility

- Reviews are not optimized for **quick evaluation**
- No strong filtering for:
 - Image-based reviews
 - Relevant item-specific feedback

Impact:

- High effort to extract useful insights
 - Over-reliance on ratings
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Product Approach

Improve the **item detail interface** to provide clearer, more reliable, and structured information, enabling users to make faster and more confident decisions.

Proposed Interface Improvements

1. "Clicked by Restaurant" Section

- New interface block showing **restaurant-uploaded real images**
- Positioned prominently on item page

Outcome:

- More accurate visual expectations
 - Reduced reliance on generic images
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2. Structured Information Display

Standardized item-level information:

- Calories (kcal)

- Allergens
- Serving size (e.g., serves 2)

Outcome:

- Improved clarity at decision point
 - Better support for dietary needs
 - Reduced ambiguity
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3. Review Section Enhancements

Sorting options:

- Low → High rating
- High → Low rating

Filtering options:

- With images
- Without images

Changes:

- More visibility to **image-backed reviews**
- Focus on **item-specific feedback**

Outcome:

- Faster evaluation
 - Higher trust in reviews
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Experimental Design

This study was conducted to:

- Validate the prevalence and relevance of the identified problem
- Evaluate the effectiveness of the proposed MVP solution

A total of **30 participants** with prior experience using food delivery platforms such as Zomato were included.

The study was conducted in two stages:

- **Problem Validation:** Understanding user challenges during item selection
 - **Solution Evaluation:** Assessing the effectiveness of the MVP
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1. Problem Validation (Pre-MVP)

Participants were asked about their experience with food delivery platforms, focusing on:

- Mismatch between displayed images and delivered food
 - Reliance on images for ordering decisions
 - Accessibility of nutritional and allergen information
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2. Solution Evaluation (Post-MVP)

Participants interacted with the MVP prototype, including:

- Food listing pages
- Item detail pages
- Review sections

No task-based instructions were provided to allow natural exploration. After interaction, participants rated the interface on **clarity, reliability, and usefulness** using a scale of 1 to 10.

MVP & Key Results

MVP Scope

A functional prototype was developed focusing on:

- Item detail interface
- Information hierarchy
- Review filtering

Key Results

Before MVP:

- 93.3% experienced image mismatch
- 83.3% rely on images but don't trust them
- 70% do not check nutritional info due to poor visibility

After MVP:

- Average rating: **8.6 / 10**
- 80% users rated ≥ 8
- Strong preference for:
 - Real images
 - Clear structured data

Expected Impact

- Increase in trust at item selection stage
- Increase in conversion confidence
- Increase in repeat usage
- Reduction in negative feedback due to expectation mismatch

Considerations

- Increased information density may affect readability
- Requires restaurant participation for real images
- Needs standardization across listings

Future Scope

- Image verification / authenticity scoring

- Standard serving size benchmarks
 - Smarter review highlighting (top insights)
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Key Takeaways

- The **item detail interface** is a critical decision point
- Lack of clarity directly impacts trust and satisfaction
- Interface-level improvements can significantly improve user confidence